

DESIGNER

JEAN PAUL GAULTIER

Dubbed the *enfant terrible* of fashion, French designer Jean Paul Gaultier catapulted onto the scene of the late 1970s, upending the status quo with his unconventional, and often humorous, avant-garde creations. Gaultier had no formal training as a designer. He started his career in 1970 as an assistant at Pierre Cardin, and then, in 1976, he scraped together funds to set up a new label for women.

His first collection included a studded leather jacket paired with a tutu. Gaultier derived inspiration from film, music, and street culture, showing a deep appreciation of multiculturalism. He loved London, attracted by the look of punk, and iconic figures such as James Bond. His first thematic collection (1979), full of miniskirts and leather trousers, brought him international attention. Gaultier went on to turn the classic idea of Parisian chic on its head. He introduced elements that became Gaultier staples: the navy-and-white striped Breton fisherman's sweater and the reconstructed trench coat.

Gender bender

In 1983 Gaultier launched the *Dadaïste* collection, establishing what would become a signature outfit: the corset. Reworking an object of female suppression, he turned it into a symbol of feminine power. (The pop star Madonna later wore Gaultier's most famous creation, a beige corset, for her 1990 *Blond Ambition* World Tour.) Gaultier jumped into menswear in 1984. Men had been reportedly buying Gaultier women's jackets because of the fabrics he used and the clever cut. Seizing the moment, Gaultier produced a sensational

catwalk show where men wore see-through skirts and women smoked pipes. Gaultier continued to play with the idea of men in skirts through the 1980s and 90s, offering a variety of styles, including kilts, sarongs, tunics, and maxi skirts. He became famous for using unconventional models such as older men, full-figured women, and heavily tattooed models, and played with gender stereotypes. A master tailor, he used details such as metal-tipped collars and extended shoulder lines to create a flattering shape, demonstrating a supreme appreciation of cut, form, and beautiful fabrics.

Further inspiration

Gaultier's interest in pulling together different cultures continued. His Autumn collection of 1993, inspired by the traditional apparel of male Hasidic Jews, was typically controversial. His profile was further raised, especially in America, when he turned his hand to costume design, creating clothes for such films as Luc Besson's *The Fifth Element*, Peter Greenaway's *The Cook, The Thief, His Wife and Her Lover*, and Pedro Almodavar's *Kikaa*.

Brand name

In 1997, disappointed not to be chosen as the new head designer at the House of Dior, Gaultier launched his first couture collection to critical acclaim. From a strapless denim ball gown to a feather and seashell dress, he has created clothes that mix outrageous features with high-quality tailoring. The Jean Paul Gaultier brand now includes jeans, eyewear, accessories, jewellery, ties, perfume, and shoes. Gaultier may have been fashion's bad boy, but he has become one of the most respected designers in the world.

**△ SHARP TAILORING**

Gaultier has become world famous for his exemplary couture skills. Here, he wears two of his signature pieces: a beautifully tailored tuxedo jacket worn over a classic Breton striped top.

◁ GREEK CHIC

Inspired by other cultures, Gaultier based his 2006 Spring/Summer couture collection on ancient Greek mythology, dressing some of his models as goddesses, with wide puffed trousers, surprising cutouts, and soft pleats.



TIMELINE

1952 Born Arcueil, France

1980 The *James Bond* collection makes a strong aesthetic statement with leather, miniskirts, and beautifully tailored silhouettes

1976 Launches first women's label at the *Palais de la Decouverte* in Paris and earns the title *enfant terrible*

1985 Introduces skirts for men in his *And God Created Man* collection

◁ 1990 Madonna's *Blond Ambition* World Tour grabs international headlines with Gaultier's conical bra and corset

1993 Launches *Chic Rabbis*, inspired by Jewish Orthodox apparel

1994 ▷ Spring/Summer show features tribal-style models and clothing

1997 Launches women's haute couture, Gaultier Paris. Designs the costumes for Luc Besson's *The Fifth Element*

2000 Receives prestigious International Award from the Council of Fashion Designers of America

2003–10 Creative director for Hermès

2012 Member of the jury at the Film Festival in Cannes

○ 1950

○ 1970

○ 1980

○ 1990

○ 2000

